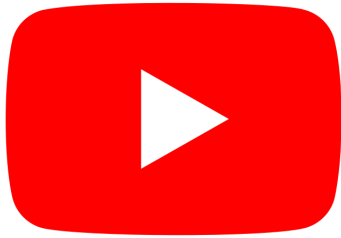


PRD - G5

# Youtube 2.0



## Product Requirement Document

Reference Sheet Link: [📄 Week 2 <> G5 <> C7](#)

### 1. Problem Space

#### 1.1 Introduction - Understanding the Problem

With the rise of short-form video content on YouTube, engagement with long-form videos (10+ minutes) has significantly declined. Reducing viewer attention spans and popularization of short form content by competing platforms has made it more palatable leaving the traditional long form content underutilized.

#### 1.2 Goal

- The goal is to enhance the visibility and appeal of long-form content based on the user's interests and viewing habits.
- Improve the Recommendation System for long form content.
- Improve engagement rate of long form video relative to the current data.

#### 1.3 Background & Context

- The metric Engagement has been chosen at YouTube to assess user interest and content quality. High engagement indicates that users are more invested in the platform, leading to longer viewing sessions and increased ad exposure.
- Since YouTube's revenue primarily comes from ads, engagement serves as a proxy for monetization potential. Content with higher engagement attracts more advertisers and can be monetized more effectively through ads, subscriptions, and partnerships.
- By tracking engagement, YouTube optimizes its content recommendations, thus driving user retention and higher ad revenue, connecting engagement directly to monetization potential

#### 1.4 Why is this problem important?

## Decrease in engagement on long form content is a cause of concern for Youtube:

- Youtube is not just a platform to watch videos. It is effectively a marketplace where creation, distribution and discovery of videos is governed by basic principles of Supply and Demand. The major players involved are creators, viewers and advertisers.
- Traditionally, Top creators (>5 Mn subscribers) have been responsible for driving maximum number of views and engagement across Youtube. And most top creators have always been creating long videos. However, post introduction of short form content, these creators have observed a decrease in views on their videos.
- It has led to loss of revenue for large creators decreasing their motivation to make new videos and restricting supply of good content.
- As Youtube relies on good content to create value, it will subsequently lead to reduction in money flow and decreasing Revenue.

Consistent loss of supply of good content in the long term will mean the death of Youtube as a platform.

Now, there are two methods to get Youtube out of this approaching death.

- Ride on success of short form content and bring better monetization plans and engagement features to drive growth forwards.
- Improve the engagement of long form content.

**Considering Youtube has traditionally been a platform of long form content and has captured a lion's share of market from its competitors, it is recommended to continue and enhance this economic moat further to grow ahead**

### 1.6 Scope

The scope of this problem is focused on:

- **Market:** India, one of YouTube's largest and fastest-growing markets, where mobile-first users dominate.
- **Platform:** The **YouTube app** (excluding YouTube Music and YouTube Kids).
- **Content Type:** Long-form content (videos over 10 minutes).
- **User Type:** Viewers primarily on mobile devices.

## 2. Research: Decoding the Existing Ecosystem

Before we can fix anything, we need to understand what is actually happening under the hood. YouTube is not just a website where videos live. It is a matchmaking machine — constantly trying to connect the right viewer with the right video at the right moment. When it works, it feels magical. When it fails, people leave.

### 2.1 YouTube as a Two-Sided Market

Think of YouTube like a farmers market. On one side, you have sellers (creators) who bring their products (videos). On the other side, you have buyers (viewers) who come looking for something worth their time. The market (YouTube) connects them — and makes money by placing ads on the tables where the most people are gathered.

The health of this market depends on both sides. If sellers stop showing up with good products, buyers leave. If buyers leave, sellers have no reason to keep making things. YouTube's job is to keep both sides healthy and talking to each other.

Right now, the market is getting unbalanced. Long-form creators are bringing fewer products. Buyers are struggling to find what they came for. The ads are still running — but they are reaching fewer attentive people. The market is at risk.

**What This Means for Us:** Any solution we build must work for both sides of the market. Helping viewers find long videos only works if creators keep making them. Helping creators only works if there are viewers watching. Both problems have to be tackled together.

2.2 The Recommendation System: How YouTube Decides What to Show

YouTube's recommendation engine is one of the most advanced pieces of technology on the internet. It processes billions of signals every hour to decide what to show each person. But like any system, it has blind spots.

The system has changed three times in big ways:

| Period      | What YouTube Optimised For                    | Why They Changed It                                        |
|-------------|-----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2005–2011   | Clicks — more clicks = more recommendations   | Videos got clickbait-y, people felt tricked                |
| 2012–2023   | Watch time — how long people actually watched | Clicks did not mean someone enjoyed the video              |
| 2025 onward | Satisfaction — did this feel worth my time?   | Watch time alone did not predict whether someone came back |

Each shift was YouTube trying to get smarter about what 'good' actually means. The latest version - satisfaction-weighted discovery - is the most honest: it does not just ask 'did they watch?' but 'did they feel the time was well spent?'

High-Level User Flow + How YouTube Matches Videos to Viewers

We did a deep-dive into the recommendation system and how Youtube tracks your journey and collects signals from the moment you open the platform.

The following flow visually shows the detailed journey along with each data signal that is tracked and used to show the next recommendation.

<https://claude.ai/public/artifacts/f73d7c25-0068-4925-b3e9-5a6ae5914ee7>

2.3 The Five Places YouTube Shows You Videos

YouTube does not have one feed — it has five different surfaces, each doing a different job:

| Surface             | What It Does                                                  | Its Goal                                  |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Home Page           | Your personalised mix — subscriptions, new creators, trending | Discover new things you might like        |
| Suggested / Up Next | Videos related to what you just watched                       | Keep your session going                   |
| Search              | You typed something specific — the most direct signal         | Give you exactly what you asked for       |
| Shorts Feed         | Swipe-based, fast, mobile-first                               | Pull in new viewers who are just browsing |
| Subscriptions       | Content from channels you follow                              | Reward your existing loyalties            |

**What This Means for Us:** The separation of Shorts and long-form algorithms is a critical design gap. A user's interest - expressed through what they watched in Shorts - is invisible to the long-form system. This is the core technical problem our solutions need to address.

## 2.4 What the Recommendation System Does Not Know

Even with all its sophistication, YouTube's system has three significant blind spots:

- **Mood vs. History:** The system knows what you watched last week. It does not know what kind of mood you are in right now. Someone who usually watches finance videos might open YouTube on a Sunday afternoon wanting something light and funny — but the algorithm keeps pushing finance content because that is the pattern it knows.
- **The Mid-Length Gap:** Videos between 4 and 8 minutes fall into a no-man's land. They are too long to be optimised like Shorts, and too short to benefit from the long-form algorithm. They get the worst of both worlds.
- **Cold Start for New Creators:** A brand-new creator with no subscribers has almost no chance of getting their long video recommended. Without subscriber data, the algorithm has no confidence in showing the video to anyone. Shorts have a much easier path to early views, which is yet another reason creators prefer making them.

[☰ YouTube\\_Discovery\\_Synthesis](#) **Detailed Doc on “How Youtube work”**

## 3. What Real Users Told Us

We surveyed 171 people to understand their real experience with long-form videos on YouTube. We wanted to know: why do people choose to watch long videos, what stops them from finding more, and what makes them leave before they finish?

3.1 User survey- Write how you have approached to the “survey form”

This primary research is based on a quantitative and qualitative survey distributed to a pool of 250–300 individuals, capturing a total of 171 responses. The survey was designed to understand user behavior, intent, and friction points specifically related to long-form video (10+ minutes) consumption on YouTube.

Demographic Breakdown:

- Age Group: The respondent base skews toward young professionals and millennials, heavily concentrated in the 25–34 range.
  - 25–34 years: ~54%
  - 35–44 years: ~25%
  - 18–24 years: ~12%
  - 45+ years: ~8.5%
  - Under 18: <1%
  -
- Gender Distribution: Based on the names provided in the survey data, the audience is fairly balanced but leans slightly male, with an estimated split of ~55% Male and ~45% Female.
- Creator Representation: Out of the total respondents, only 3 users identified as active long-form content creators (having uploaded videos in the last 6-12 months). Because of this small sample size, the "Creator Branch" questions provide directional, qualitative insights rather than strict statistical evidence.

| Research Theme       | Objective                             | Key Variables Captured                           | Sample Survey Questions                                                                                                    | Insight Type Expected                     |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Demographics         | Understand audience segmentation      | Age                                              | What is your age?                                                                                                          | Behavioral differences across age cohorts |
| General Usage        | Measure platform intensity            | Weekly watch time, session frequency             | On average, how much time do you spend watching YouTube videos each week?                                                  | Engagement baseline & usage patterns      |
| Long-Form Engagement | Identify why users choose long videos | Motivation, click frequency, completion behavior | What is the main reason you watch videos longer than 10 minutes?When YouTube suggests long videos, how often do you click? | Intent behind long-form consumption       |

|                               |                                          |                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                          |                                           |
|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| <b>Drop-Off Triggers</b>      | Understand abandonment causes            | Skipping behavior, early exits                     | What is the main reason you stop watching before a long video finishes? How often do you skip through long videos?                                                       | Retention friction signals                |
| <b>Discovery &amp; Intent</b> | Analyze entry points & search behavior   | Content types searched, browsing intent            | Think about the last few times you opened YouTube. What were you looking for?                                                                                            | Demand mapping & algorithm influence      |
| <b>Feature Validation</b>     | Test appetite for long-form enhancements | Chapter usage, summaries, navigation improvements  | If YouTube made it easier to find specific parts within a long video, would you watch more long videos?                                                                  | Validation of potential product solutions |
| <b>Creation Experience</b>    | Understand creator-side friction         | Upload behavior, motivation, production challenges | Have you uploaded a video? What is the biggest challenge when making 10+ min videos? If you could change one thing about YouTube's long-video support, what would it be? | Supply-side constraints & feature gaps    |

Insights from our survey: grouped by the four groups who matter most.

### 3.1 What Viewers Said

The clearest message from viewers was this: they want long videos, but YouTube is not helping them find or finish them.

- 59% of viewers said they stop watching a long video because it feels slow or stretched out — not because they lost interest in the topic. They still wanted to learn; the video just failed them.
- 47% of people say they have to manually search for long videos every time. The home screen does not surface them. Only 32% of people ever discover a long video just by opening the app.
- 58% of people do not finish the long videos they start. They skip around or just stop — even when they originally sat down to watch.

**What This Means for Us:** People are not giving up on long-form content. They are giving up on YouTube's ability to show it to them. The interest is there. The discovery and quality are failing.

### 3.2 What the Product Signals Showed

Beyond what people said, the survey revealed some patterns about how YouTube is actually behaving:

- 49% of users have to search manually for long videos. Only 32% ever find them on their home screen. The most visited page on YouTube is actively working against long-form discovery.
- 22% of people stop watching a long video because a suggested video on the side caught their eye. The platform is competing against itself.
- After watching a Short, only 15% of people actively look for a longer video from the same creator. But 41% say they would watch one if it were easy to find. The demand is there — the pathway is not.

### 3.3 What Creators Said

We only had a small sample of creators in this survey, so these findings are directional rather than statistically definitive — but the pattern was clear and consistent:

- Making a 10–15 minute video takes 12–20 hours of work. Making five Shorts takes 2–4 hours. The effort gap is enormous, and AI tools have mostly helped with Shorts, not long-form.
- 11% of survey respondents — regular viewers, not creators — said they used to make videos and quit in the last year. This quiet attrition is happening below the surface.

### 3.4 What Advertisers Are Experiencing

Advertisers were not a focus of this survey, but they showed up anyway — in the comments people left without being asked:

- 30% of written comments mentioned ads as a frustration — without a single question asking about ads. That is how strongly people feel about it.
- 70% of people watch long videos to learn deeply. Unskippable ads break that concentration at exactly the moment people are most engaged.
- Several users wrote that forced ads created negative feelings toward the brand being advertised — the opposite of what advertisers are paying for.

**What This Means for Us:** The ad problem is real and urgent, but it sits in a different workstream from discovery. We are flagging it here because it directly affects completion rates — which affect creator revenue — which affects how much long-form content gets made. Everything is connected.

This [dashboard visualizes primary research findings](#) from a 176-person survey on YouTube long-form video behavior. It breaks down friction points across four stakeholder groups - users, product, creators, and advertisers - surfacing where the experience is breaking down and why. Use it as the data foundation for the problem statements in this PRD.

## 4. Secondary Research

### Evidence Behind the Long-Form Discovery Problem

This section consolidates external market, behavioral, and ecosystem data to validate whether long-form engagement decline is structural, temporary, or discovery-driven.

#### 4.1 Market Reality: Long-Form Is Still the Majority



| Metric                        | Value              |  | Confidence |
|-------------------------------|--------------------|--|------------|
| Global MAU                    | 2.53B (Jan 2025)   |  | HIGH       |
| India MAU                     | 491M (~20% global) |  | HIGH       |
| Total Revenue                 | \$60B+ (2025)      |  | HIGH       |
| Shorts Daily Views            | 200B (Jan 2026)    |  | HIGH       |
| Long-Form Share of Watch Time | 70%+               |  | HIGH       |

### Key Observations

1. Long-form still accounts for the majority of total watch time (70%+).
2. Shorts generate massive daily views (200B), indicating strong attention capture.
3. India is YouTube's largest user base and monetizes primarily through ads.
4. Subscription growth is increasing globally, but India remains ad-dependent.

### Insight

- Long-form is not in structural decline in terms of consumption share. However, Shorts are absorbing a growing portion of feed attention.

💡 The issue is not lack of long-form consumption — it is feed displacement.

### 4.2 Device Shift: Where Long-Form Thrives

| Metric                     | Value                | Confidence |
|----------------------------|----------------------|------------|
| TV share of US watch hours | 36% (H1 2025)        | MED        |
| Long-form on TV            | 73% of TV watch time | MED        |
| Global CTV Devices         | 2.65B → 4.2B by 2030 | MED        |

### Insight

- Long-form performs strongest on CTV (lean-back behavior). Shorts dominate mobile discovery surfaces.
- In mobile-first markets like India, long-form competes directly with swipe behavior.

**Discovery design must account for device context. Long-form does not fail on TV - it struggles in mobile feed environments.**

4.3 Monetization & Creator Incentives

| Metric                     | Long-Form | Shorts        | Confidence |
|----------------------------|-----------|---------------|------------|
| Creator RPM (per 1K views) | \$3–\$6   | \$0.03–\$0.07 | MED        |
| Revenue Share              | 55%       | 45% pool      | MED        |
| Short-form Ad CAGR         | 13.68%    | —             | MED        |

Observations

1. Long-form earns significantly higher per-view revenue.
2. Shorts ad budgets are growing faster globally.
3. Per-watch-hour revenue is roughly equal (Q3 2025 earnings).

Insight

Creators observe per-view economics, not per-hour parity.

This creates a tension:

- Shorts grow faster.
- Long-form pays better per view.
- AI reduces short-form production effort.

Discovery must protect long-form supply incentives.

4.4 Discovery Friction: Behavioral Evidence

| Metric                         | Value                    | Confidence |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------|------------|
| Avg Search Time per Session    | 12 min (↑60% since 2019) | MED        |
| Session Abandonment (All Ages) | 19%                      | MED        |
| Session Abandonment (18–24)    | 29%                      | MED        |
| Gen Z Long-Form Preference     | 51%                      | MED        |
| Gen Z Long-Form Viewership     | 53.1%                    | MED        |

Key Observations

1. Gen Z does not reject long-form.
2. 51% call it a favorite format.

3. 29% of Gen Z sessions end without watching a video.
4. Users spend ~30% of session time searching.

### Insight

- The problem is not content rejection. It is discovery friction.
- A 12-minute search overhead in a 40-minute session is ~30% unmonetized time.
- Reducing search friction directly increases engagement potential.

### 4.5 Behavioral Shift: Long-Form vs Short-Form

| Dimension             | Long-Form                | Short-Form                        | Direction    |
|-----------------------|--------------------------|-----------------------------------|--------------|
| Share of Watch Time   | 70%+                     | ~10%                              | LF dominant  |
| Engagement Trend 2025 | Stable in instructional  | Shorts -47% YoY                   | LF stable    |
| Post Volume Trend     | Stable                   | +71% posts, engagement 4-year low | SF fatigue   |
| Within-channel Views  | Lower post-Shorts launch | 110x higher                       | SF advantage |

### Observations

1. Long-form remains dominant in total watch time.
2. Short-form is showing engagement fatigue despite supply growth.
3. Within-channel cannibalization exists but evidence is directional.

### Insight

- Short-form is not infinitely expanding attention. Supply growth is outpacing engagement.
- This increases competition within feed real estate.

### 4.6 Ecosystem Growth & Content Supply

| Factor              | Long-Form    | Shorts      |
|---------------------|--------------|-------------|
| Edit Time           | 12–20 hrs    | 2–4 hrs     |
| Approx Cost         | \$500–\$800  | \$100–\$200 |
| AI Editing Adoption | 50%+ overall |             |

### Insight

- AI lowers cost for both formats, but the effort gap remains.
- Short-form scales faster due to lower effort and faster validation.

- Long-form requires higher investment and higher discovery confidence.

If discovery is unpredictable, long-form supply declines over time.

4.8 Consolidated Secondary Insights

1. Long-form remains 70%+ of watch time - not collapsing.
2. Shorts dominate mobile feed discovery.
3. Discovery friction has increased (12-min search time).
4. Gen Z prefers long-form but struggles to find it.
5. AI increases supply and compresses informational demand.
6. Short-form engagement shows signs of fatigue.
7. Shorts → Long transition rate is unverified.

What the Data Tells Us

- Long-form content is not in structural decline.
- It thrives on TV and maintains majority watch time.
- The problem is not content quality.
- The problem is feed design and discovery friction.
- Shorts absorb passive attention.
- AI increases content competition.
- Users spend more time searching.
- Gen Z abandons sessions despite liking long-form.
- Discovery is the structural bottleneck.

Secondary Research detailed doc - check for each section here in detail :  
[📄 YouTube\\_Discovery\\_Synthesis](#)

5. Competitor Landscape: Where Long-Form Attention Is Going

YouTube does not have a single direct competitor that replaces its entire ecosystem. However, long-form engagement is being pressured because different platforms capture different viewing contexts.

Each competitor takes a specific type of user moment.

5.1 Fragmentation of Viewing Moments

| Competitor | What They Capture      | How                     | Impact on YouTube Long-Form                         |
|------------|------------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| TikTok     | Casual, idle scrolling | Endless short-form feed | Conditions users toward low time-commitment viewing |

|          |                              |                                      |                                         |
|----------|------------------------------|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Netflix  | Intentional evening sessions | Lean-back, premium long-form content | Captures extended viewing sessions      |
| AI Tools | Learning and quick answers   | Instant responses                    | Reduces need for explainer-style videos |

### What This Means

- TikTok captures passive attention before a long session begins.
- Netflix captures deliberate, high-intent long sessions.
- AI tools capture informational intent that previously drove explainer views.

**YouTube sits between these use cases.**

**The risk is not user migration - it is loss of specific viewing moments.**

### 5.2 What Other Platforms Tried - and What Failed

Several platforms attempted to improve long-form discovery. Most attempts failed for predictable reasons.

| Platform                     | Attempt                    | Outcome                      | Learning                                              |
|------------------------------|----------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Instagram (IGTV)             | Separate long-form tab     | Shut down                    | Users do not adopt new in-app destinations            |
| Netflix ("Play Something")   | Random content button      | Removed                      | Randomness without context reduces trust              |
| Netflix ("Fast Laughs")      | Short clips inside Netflix | Discontinued                 | Mixing formats without intent clarity fails           |
| Netflix (Autoplay)           | Auto-play next episode     | Still active                 | Reducing friction within format increases consumption |
| TikTok (Long-form expansion) | Extended video duration    | Long videos gaining traction | Even short-form platforms value long-form             |

### 5.3 Key Insights

1. Long-form demand still exists across platforms.

2. Attention is fragmented across contexts - not replaced by one competitor.
3. Passive short-form conditioning affects willingness to start long sessions.
4. Dedicated long-session time is moving toward streaming platforms.
5. Informational long-form faces substitution from AI tools.
6. Discovery improvements must live inside existing feed surfaces.
7. The critical unknown remains: how effectively Shorts convert to long-form sessions.

### Final Implication

**YouTube does not need to create new destinations for long-form.**

**It needs to improve how long-form is surfaced and transitioned inside the current experience.**

**The competitive pressure is structural fragmentation of attention. The opportunity lies in improving discovery at the moment of intent shift.**

## 6. Prioritisation Context

**After completing primary and secondary research, one thing became clear:**

- The problem is not that long-form content has disappeared. The problem is that the right users are not reaching it easily - especially on mobile.
- Long-form still holds the majority of watch time globally. Creators still earn more from it per session. Gen Z still prefers it for learning and depth.
- However, Mobile feeds are dominated by Shorts. Discovery friction is rising.
- Session abandonment among young users is increasing. Creators are shifting effort toward Shorts due to predictability.

| Dimension | Our Choice       | Why This Matters                                                        |
|-----------|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Platform  | YouTube Main App | Discovery problem exists inside the main feed                           |
| Geography | India            | Largest mobile-first growth market                                      |
| Device    | Mobile           | Shorts-dominant surface where long-form is under-discovered             |
| Age Group | 18–34            | Highest abandonment, highest Shorts conditioning, still value long-form |

|                   |                                              |                                                 |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Format            | Long-form (10+ min)                          | Drives depth, session time, and creator revenue |
| Genre Focus       | Education, skills, business, deep commentary | Natural long-form use cases                     |
| Stakeholder Focus | User discovery + creator confidence          | Break both demand and supply loop               |

6.1 Primary Persona (With Rationale)

Persona: The Intentional Learner

We are prioritising this persona because research shows:

- 70% of long-form viewers watch to understand something deeply.
- 47% must manually search each session.
- 29% of Gen Z sessions end without watching anything.
- 41% say they would move from Shorts to long-form if it were easy.
- Many are now using AI tools instead of watching full explainers.

| Attribute | Details                                               |
|-----------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Age       | 18–34                                                 |
| Device    | Mobile-first                                          |
| Intent    | Purpose-driven (learn, build skill, understand topic) |
| Behavior  | Search-heavy, low trust in homepage                   |

|             |                                     |
|-------------|-------------------------------------|
| Frustration | Time wasted finding the right video |
| Risk        | Switches to AI or exits app         |

## 6.2. Prioritised Pain Points

We are focusing on three core problems.

### Pain Point 1: “I Can’t Find What I Came For.”

Long-Form Discovery Feels Hard: Users open YouTube on mobile but do not naturally see relevant long videos in their feed. Most of the time, they have to manually search to find something meaningful. Discovery feels effort-heavy. When finding content starts to feel like work, users either settle for Shorts or leave the app. The problem is not lack of content - it is difficulty in reaching it.

### Pain Point 2: “What If This Video Wastes My Time?”

Starting a Long Video Feels Risky: A 20-minute video feels like a commitment. Users cannot easily judge if it will actually deliver value. Thumbnails look similar. Intros are often slow. Many videos feel stretched. Compared to this, Shorts feel safer because the time commitment is low. So users hesitate before starting long videos, and hesitation reduces engagement

### Pain Point 3: “Why Should I Spend 15 Hours on Something That Might Not Get Seen?”

Creators spend significantly more time producing long videos, but algorithm visibility feels unpredictable. Results are slower and less certain compared to Shorts, which provide faster reach and feedback. Over time, creators shift effort toward Shorts. When long-form supply reduces, discovery becomes even harder - reinforcing the same cycle.

### How these three problems connect

These are not three separate problems. They are three parts of the same problem.

The home feed stops showing long videos, so users don't find them. The users who do find long videos leave early because the content is padded. Creators see low completion rates and poor earnings, so they stop making long videos. Which means the home feed has even less good content to show. Which means users find less, watch less, and trust the platform less.

It is a loop. And it has been running quietly for a while. The three solutions in this PRD — Deep Dive Tab, Shorts-to-Long Bridge, Long-Form Viewing Streak, and Creator Success Suite — are designed to break that loop at three different points at the same time.

| Problem | What is actually happening | Where we intervene |
|---------|----------------------------|--------------------|
|---------|----------------------------|--------------------|



|           |                                                                                                                  |                                                                       |
|-----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>P1</b> | The home screen isn't surfacing long videos, so users search manually or give up                                 | Deep Dive Tab + Shorts-to-Long Bridge + Long-Form Viewing Streak      |
| <b>P2</b> | Videos are padded because of how ad rules work — users leave early, which makes the economics worse for everyone | Creator Success Suite — quality score before publishing               |
| <b>P3</b> | Creators find long-form too hard and too uncertain, so they're quietly switching to short videos                 | Creator Success Suite — AI tools to reduce production effort and cost |

### 6.3 What We Are Not Fixing Right Now

Our research also surfaced problems we chose not to tackle in this version — not because they do not matter, but because the discovery and creator problems are the foundation everything else sits on. Solving these first:

| Problem We're Deferring                    | Why Not Now                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Too many ads, especially unskippable ones  | 30% of written comments brought this up without being asked. But changing ad behaviour is a monetisation decision that needs a separate workstream with different stakeholders. |
| The TV and desktop experience being clunky | Veeru's biggest frustration. But improving that experience only matters if we first get more people there — and right now, discovery is failing before they ever reach a TV.    |
| AI summaries replacing the need to watch   | Some users already use YouTube's AI summary to skip videos. Addressing this requires decisions about creator revenue that go beyond this team's scope.                          |

**What This Means for Us:** The solutions in this PRD are designed to be native to surfaces YouTube users already visit. We are not building new tabs that require users to change their behaviour. We are reducing friction inside the journey they are already on. That is the only approach the competitor evidence tells us can work.

## 7. Solution Structure

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### 7.1 Solution 1 - Deep Dive Tab

**Vertical Solution - directly addresses P1: The Home Feed Has Stopped Working for Long-Form**

**What It Is** A dedicated tab on YouTube positioned second in the navigation bar after Home, built entirely around intentional long-form consumption. Users declare their interest categories — PM, Podcasts, Finance, Football - and the tab organises all long-form content around those declared interests. No Shorts appear anywhere inside it. It is not a feed replacement — it is a purposeful destination a user enters when they want to go deep, separating long-form discovery entirely from the short-form-dominated Home screen.

**How It Works** On first entry a 30-second onboarding screen pre-populates 5–6 interest categories from watch history as large visual tiles. The user confirms or adjusts, subscribed creators are automatically mapped into each category, and the tab is live immediately. Inside each category, four sections stack in priority order: a pinned Continue Watching strip at the top for videos started but not finished, each with a progress bar and resume timestamp; New from Your Creators shows the latest videos from the set of creators chronologically or through the recommendation engine - This would be a user picked setting during setup of the Deep Dive space; Deep Picks surfacing quality-ranked recommendations from creators the user does not yet follow, each card showing chapter previews and a trust signal like "81% of viewers finish this"; and Creator Spotlight rotating weekly to introduce one unfamiliar creator's top three long-form videos in the category. A horizontally scrollable category pill row at the top filters the entire page instantly on tap.

**Key Innovation** Deep Picks ranks content by completion rate and rewatch signals — not view count. This is the structural difference from every existing YouTube surface. High view count is a popularity signal. Completion rate is a quality signal. For long-form content these two are frequently in conflict, and every existing YouTube surface optimises for the wrong one.

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<https://claude.ai/public/artifacts/1f8b3962-5f05-4494-864a-1c4f488ccdbe> - Deep Dive User Flow Diagram.

<https://curious-kernel.lovable.app/> - Lovable Preview

### 7.2 Solution 2 - Long-Form Viewing Streak

**Lateral Solution - addresses P1 through behaviour change, not product surface**

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**What It Is** A weekly topic-based habit mechanic that rewards users for consistently engaging with long-form content in their declared Deep Dive categories. The core unit is a weekly streak — watch 3 qualifying long-form videos (15 min+, 75% completion) in one topic category per week and the streak

advances by one week. It lives inside the Deep Dive tab and is designed to feel like a personal viewing progress tracker, not a platform engagement counter. "You have maintained your PM learning habit for 6 weeks" is a statement of personal growth — the language, design, and rewards consistently reinforce this framing.

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**How It Works** Two streak types run in parallel. A Topic Streak that is user triggered tracks progress per declared category independently- a user with PM, Finance, and Podcasts has three separate streaks, each requiring its own 3 qualifying videos per week. A Deep Watch meta-streak advances if the user qualifies on any one category in a given week, giving casual viewers a persistent headline number even when focus shifts across topics.

Qualification rules: video must be 15 minutes minimum, user must reach 75% completion at any playback speed including 2x, chapter-jumping counts if total content covered reaches 75%. If the qualifying video is part of a creator playlist, it counts as a single video toward streak — completing the full playlist is optional and never required. One grace week per calendar month protects the streak from a single missed week.

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**Milestone Progression and Recommendation Flow**

The shift from individual video recommendations to playlist recommendations is the core progression mechanic. No content-level classification is needed — the transition is triggered purely by streak depth.

| Milestone | Reward                                                            | Recommendation Type                                               |
|-----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Week 3    | Consistent Viewer Badge                                           | 1 curated long-form video recommendation in that category         |
| Week 6    | Personalised Viewing summary card (hours watched, topics covered) | Shifts from video to creator playlist recommendation              |
| Week 12   | The Pathbreaker                                                   | Shifts from creator playlists to broader playlist recommendations |

**Phase 1 (Weeks 1-5):** Deep Picks surfaces individual video recommendations. Standard recommendation logic applies, biased toward the declared category. Week 3 makes this explicit with a single surfaced recommendation card so the user sees the streak is delivering something tangible.

**Phase 2 (Weeks 6-11):** Recommendation type shifts to creator playlists. No new taxonomy needed. The explicit unlock message: "You've watched consistently for 6 weeks — here's a structured playlist to go deeper." YouTube is not judging content level, it is simply recommending a playlist format over a standalone video.

**Phase 3 (Week 12+):** The mechanic graduates the user from creator playlists to broader playlists in that category. The framing shifts: You have moved past the "paved road" of introductory content and are now finding your own way through the topic. Streak continues with no ceiling, but reward type stabilises into ongoing creator playlist recommendations refreshed periodically.

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**Key Innovation** The recommendation type itself evolves with the user's demonstrated commitment. Early streak users get videos because that is the lowest friction entry point. Users who sustain six weeks have shown enough intent to benefit from structured playlists. Users who sustain twelve weeks have outgrown curated playlists and need breadth, not more structure. YouTube is not making any judgment about content difficulty or user expertise — it is simply matching recommendation format to demonstrated behaviour depth.

Three notification types only, all opt-in, each firing with the specific recommended video or playlist attached so the user never opens YouTube from a streak notification and has to decide what to watch.

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**Wireframe** - <https://claude.ai/public/artifacts/47d1977b-2b20-466f-904f-a709bd822e25>

### 7.3 Solution 3 - Shorts-to-Long-Form Contextual Bridge

**Vertical Solution** - *directly addresses P1: passive discovery failure and the format-switching gap*

**What It Is** A behaviour-triggered bridge card that appears inside the Shorts feed at the moment a user has demonstrated genuine topic interest — after watching a Short to 95% completion and having watched 3 or more Shorts on the same topic in one session. Instead of showing another random Short, the platform surfaces a Deep Dive Preview card: a 45–90 second highlight clip from a related long-form video, displayed in the same vertical Shorts format, with a visible "Watch Full Video" CTA and the full video length shown clearly. If the user taps, the long-form video opens. If they swipe, they continue watching Shorts normally. Nothing is interrupted. Nothing is forced. A second layer activates after 5 continuous minutes of Shorts scrolling — a slim non-intrusive banner at the top of the feed reading "4 new videos in Product Management — Go Deep?" with one tap leading directly to the Deep Dive tab.

**How It Works** Trigger rules require 95% Short completion plus 3+ same-topic Shorts in one session — both signals must be true, preventing irrelevant bridge cards from appearing after casual scrolling. One bridge card appears every 5 Shorts maximum to preserve the Shorts session experience. Matching logic uses topic similarity and excludes already-watched videos. A learning system adjusts future suggestions based on outcome — if the user exits the long video in under 60 seconds, similar suggestions are reduced; if they watch more than 5 minutes, similar recommendations are boosted. Risk control: if Shorts session length drops by more than 5% in A/B testing, bridge card frequency is reduced before any broader rollout.

**Key Innovation** This is not a same-creator link. Every existing YouTube mechanism that connects Shorts to long-form is creator-dependent — it shows more from the same channel. This bridge is

system-level, cross-creator, and behaviour-triggered. It activates on what the user just demonstrated interest in, not on who made the content. A user who watched three Shorts about product management will see a Deep Dive Preview about that or related topic of a long-form PM video on the platform regardless of whether they follow that creator. The discovery surface is intent-matched, not subscription-matched.

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<https://claude.ai/public/artifacts/b0af1dca-07fb-41cc-8120-c16df7710001> - User Flow Diagram.

**Lovable Link** - <https://bridge-to-depth.lovable.app/>

## 7.4 Solution 4 - Creator Success Suite

**Lateral Solution** - *directly addresses P2: The Padding Loop and P3: Long-Form Creators Are Already Quitting*

**What It Is** A set of AI-powered tools built directly into YouTube Studio that reduces the effort, cost, and skill barrier of making long-form content — addressing P3 at the supply level — while simultaneously introducing a pre-publish Content Quality Score that penalises padding before a video goes live, addressing P2 at the source. Today big creators with production teams have a structural advantage. A solo creator with a phone cannot compete. The Creator Success Suite changes that equation without touching the algorithm or monetisation rules.

**How It Works** Two core pillars. The AI Creation Lab gives every creator a built-in toolkit inside YouTube Studio: AI script generator, AI video editor suggesting cuts and chapter markers, auto-captions in 12 Indian languages plus English, AI thumbnail generator, and SEO-optimised title and description drafts. Tool access is tiered by subscriber count so new creators see a guided simple view while large creators get API access and batch uploads. The Content Quality Score runs before every publish — scoring hook strength, pacing, depth, and engagement potential on a 0–100 scale — and gives creators timestamped suggestions like "trim intro from 1:10–2:00 to improve hook." The score is not public, not linked to monetisation, and purely advisory. It fixes padding before it reaches viewers rather than penalising it after.

**Key Innovation** The Content Quality Score is a pre-publish intervention — the only point in the creator workflow where the platform can influence content quality before it damages viewer trust. Every other platform mechanism responds to underperformance after the fact. This acts before the video goes live, turning quality improvement into a gamified pre-publish ritual rather than a post-hoc analytics exercise. It directly breaks the padding loop at its origin point.

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**Lovable Link** - <https://youtube-studio-boost.lovable.app/>

# Youtube Ecosystem

# YouTube Platform Research Synthesis

## 2.1 What is YouTube?

YouTube is the world's largest video-sharing platform, where anyone - from a teenager in their bedroom to a major TV network can upload content, and anyone else can watch it for free.

YouTube is a two-sided platform -  
on one side are creators who make videos,  
and on the other side are viewers who watch them.

The platform connects both and makes money mainly by showing ads.

💡 Any gap in this matchmaking = a gap in value for both viewers and creators.

## 2.2 What Problem Does YouTube Solve?

Before YouTube, if you wanted to watch a video, you had to:

- Buy a DVD or CD
- Wait for it on TV at a fixed time
- Have expensive equipment to record or share videos

**YouTube solved 3 big problems at once:**

| Problem                                  | How YouTube Fixed It                               |
|------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| To find videos on a topic you care about | Search + Recommendations surface the right content |
| To share your own videos with the world  | Anyone can upload for free                         |
| To watch what you want, when you want    | On-demand viewing, anytime, on any device          |

💡 YouTube's core job - helping people find the content most worth their attention. But today, with billions of videos available, the discovery problem has gotten harder, not easier.

## 2.3 Impact of YouTube

YouTube didn't just change how we watch videos. It changed how we learn, earn, and what "being famous" even means.

Creators now build bigger audiences from their bedrooms (unlike old TV Fame days), and “YouTuber” is a top dream job worldwide.

Learning is free and global, with everyday people teaching skills once limited to institutions. A teen in a small town now starts on equal footing with someone in a big city.

With 2.7 billion active users, YouTube has created entirely new careers from creators to editors to sponsorship managers powering a billion-dollar influencer economy.

💡 Whoever understands the algorithm holds the key to reach. Creators who understand how the system thinks can grow faster.

2.4 YouTube’s Presence: India vs. Global Markets

Mobile usage is dominant in India - and YouTube recognizes that Shorts are watched more on mobile, while long-form videos are watched more on desktop.

| Factor                   | India Context                   | Global Context               |
|--------------------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------|
| Primary device           | Mobile-first                    | Mix of mobile + desktop + TV |
| Content type dominant    | Shorts (mobile)                 | Long-form on TV/desktop      |
| Regional recommendations | Yes - local content prioritized | Language + location-based    |
| Creator economy stage    | Growing fast                    | More mature                  |

💡 India’s mobile-first behavior means - Shorts are the dominant discovery format here. Any feature designed to help viewers find the right content must be built mobile-first to work in the Indian market.

2.5 How YouTube Works

YouTube’s Personalization and Recommendation System

High-Level User Flow + How YouTube Matches Videos to Viewers

We did a deep-dive into the recommendation system and how Youtube tracks your journey and collects signals from the moment you open the platform.



The following flow visually shows the detailed journey along with each data signal that is tracked and used to show the next recommendation.

<https://claude.ai/public/artifacts/f73d7c25-0068-4925-b3e9-5a6ae5914ee7>

Youtube has updated its recommendations in 3 major phases over the years :-

| Year          | Changes                                                                                                                                                            | Reason                                                                     |
|---------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2005–2011:    | Optimized for clicks - the more clicks a video got, the more it was recommended. This created clickbait.                                                           | basic KPI in initial stage                                                 |
| 2012–2023:    | Introduced watch time as the main signal. When they made this change, views dropped 20% - but they kept it anyway because it delivered more real value to viewers. | clicks were not good enough for tracking as people can leave videos midway |
| 2025 onwards: | Shifted to satisfaction-weighted discovery - the question is not just “did they watch?” but “did they feel the time was worth it?”                                 | goal was now long term retention, and to foster mindful engagement         |

2.6 How the System Builds Your Taste Profile

Positive signals: - Thumbnail click, watch duration, Survey responses (rating videos 1–5 stars), Likes, shares, comments - Watching more videos after this one.

Negative signals: Leaving the video in the first few seconds (the most damaging signal - it means the thumbnail “lied” about what the video was), Clicking - Not Interested/Don’t Recommend Channel. Signal weights are personal. If you share YT about videos you disliked, the system learns and adapts.

2.8 The 5 Discovery Surfaces

| Surface             | What it Does                                              | Goal                           |
|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Homepage            | Most personalized - mix of subs, new, and similar viewers | Interest expansion + discovery |
| Suggested / Up Next | Based on current video + your broader interests           | Keep session going             |
| Search              | You’ve declared what you want - most explicit signal      | Intent satisfaction            |

|               |                                        |                        |
|---------------|----------------------------------------|------------------------|
| Shorts Feed   | Swipe-based, passive, mobile-first     | New audience discovery |
| Subscriptions | Shows content from channels you follow | Loyalty reinforcement  |

💡 Creators and users don't understand why something was recommended to them, which creates a feeling of being "trapped" in a content loop.

💡 After mid 2025, the recommendation system is separate for - Short form and long form.

### 2.7 Challenges in the Current Recommendation System

Even though YouTube's recommendation system is one of the most advanced in the world, it has real structural gaps:

1. **Mood vs. History** - It's great at keeping you watching, but doesn't know when you're done. Your past behavior shapes recommendations, even when your current mood has changed.
2. **Mid-Length Content Gap** - Videos in the 4-8 minute range aren't optimized like Shorts or long-form.
3. **New Creator Discovery** - With no subscriber base, new creators struggle to reach their first audience.

💡 The biggest gap is the mismatch between mood and history. The system understands your past, but not your current intent creating an opportunity for smarter, real-time context signals.

### 2.8 Decoding Long-Form vs. Short-Form Content in the AI Era

Since 2025, these are *fully decoupled* - different algorithm engines, different signals, different goals.

| Dimension            | Long-Form                                      | Shorts                                |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Viewer intent        | Active, deliberate choice                      | Passive discovery via swipe           |
| Format trigger       | Horizontal (16:9) OR more than 3 minutes       | Vertical (9:16) AND 3 minutes or less |
| Primary metric       | CTR, Watch Time                                | Viewed vs. Swiped Away ratio          |
| Retention measure    | Minutes watched + % retained                   | Completion rate + loop/replay count   |
| Satisfaction signals | Surveys, likes, comments, session continuation | Replays, shares, comment sentiment    |

|              |                                  |                                      |
|--------------|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Monetization | Higher CPM, ad revenue per watch | Lower revenue per view, faster reach |
| Device       | Desktop + TV favored             | Mobile-first                         |

**Long-Form Distribution (Wave Model):** When a long video goes live, YouTube shows it to a small group of people who might like it. If they engage well, it shows it to a slightly bigger group. This wave keeps growing until engagement drops. But the video never dies - a trending topic, a shoutout, or a cultural moment can restart the wave.

**Shorts Distribution (Explore > Exploit Model):** When a Short is uploaded, YouTube runs an experiment. It shows the Short to a small test audience (a few hundred to a few thousand). If they watch most of it or replay it - green light. The algorithm shifts to “exploit” mode and pushes it to larger audiences with similar interests.

**Engagement Speed Comparison**

| Factor                  | Shorts Advantage                        | Long-Form Disadvantage                         |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Engagement accumulation | Millions of views in hours              | Days to weeks for equivalent mass              |
| Completion ease         | 15–60 seconds is naturally completeable | 40%+ abandonment is normal but still penalized |
| Algorithm testing speed | Seed audience feedback in hours         | Testing window stretches days                  |
| Discovery reach         | Shown to non-subscribers by default     | Primarily shown to existing subscribers first  |

**What AI is Changing**

In 2025, YouTube integrated LLMs into its recommendation engine - shifting from pattern-matching to actually understanding content and viewer intent.

AI-powered features like auto-captions and auto-chapters are now native. But overuse of mass-produced AI content can label videos as “low effort” and reduce reach, and creators must disclose synthetic or AI-generated content.

💡 AI is rapidly increasing content volume. More supply means tougher competition - raising the quality bar and widening the gap between creators who understand the system and those who don’t.

**2.9 Overall Insights**

## The Big Picture

YouTube is running two parallel bets:

- Shorts = Discovery Engine - fast, passive, mobile-first, built for new audience acquisition. Rewards the first 2 seconds above everything else.
- Long-Form = Loyalty Engine - deliberate viewing, session depth, trust-building, evergreen content, higher ad revenue, deeper audience relationships.

The platform is clearly trying to keep both alive - but there's a growing tension between them.

### 1. Key Patterns from the Data

**1. The Algorithm Hierarchy (Most to Least Important)** Watch Time → Audience Retention → Post-Watch Behavior → Satisfaction Surveys → “Not Interested” signals → Comments → CTR → Replays → Shares → Likes → Subscriptions from video

### 2. Engagement Rate Thresholds

| ER% (Likes + Comments + Shares / Views × 100) | What It Means                                           |
|-----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Under 2%                                      | Content not resonating - deprioritized                  |
| 2–4%                                          | Average - neutral distribution                          |
| 4–6%                                          | Strong - favored in suggestions                         |
| 6%+                                           | Exceptional - algorithmic boost, up to 2× organic reach |

### 3. Retention Thresholds by Video Length

| Video Length | Good Retention | Great Retention |
|--------------|----------------|-----------------|
| Under 2 min  | 50–70%         | 80%+            |
| 2–5 min      | 60%+           | 75%+            |

|          |        |      |
|----------|--------|------|
| 5–10 min | 50%+   | 65%+ |
| 10+ min  | 40–60% | 65%+ |

Note: Below 40% retention = deprioritized regardless of CTR.

**4. Creator Combo Advantage** Creators who use **both long-form and short-form together** see a **40% increase in engagement**. Shorts act as a discovery funnel; long-form converts that audience into loyal subscribers.

**5. Comment Timing Matters** Channels that reply to 50+ comments in the first 2 hours see **15–20% higher reach**. Videos that earn 50% of their engagement in the first 24 hours see **3× higher organic reach**.

### The Structural Gaps (Summary)

| Gap                             | What it Means                                                                 |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Mood ≠ History                  | The system knows your past but not your present state of mind                 |
| Middle-ground content (4–8 min) | Falls between both algorithm engines - neither Shorts nor long-form optimized |
| No creation tools for Shorts    | Short-form creators get almost no native tools to create better content       |
| Black box recommendations       | Viewers don't understand why something is recommended                         |
| AI content quality line unclear | Creators don't know where the "low effort AI" line is                         |
| New creator cold start          | Without subscribers, long-form is much harder to launch than Shorts           |

💡 YouTube is built for scale, but still delivers a largely one-size-fits-all feed.

The real opportunity lies in intent-aware personalization - understanding not just who you are from past behavior, but what you want right now based on context and mood.

# Secondary Research Detailed Document

## 4. Secondary Research

### 4.1 Market Share of YouTube

On the revenue side, YouTube crossed \$60B in total revenue in 2025 (Alphabet Q4 SEC Filing  HIGH), with subscription revenue growing from 20% to 33% of total in three years - signalling a structural shift away from pure ad dependency, particularly relevant for markets outside India.

| Metric                        | Value                             | Source                      | Insight # | Confidence                                                                                |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------|-----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Global MAU                    | 2.53B (Jan 2025)                  | DataReportal Digital 2025   | #08, #04  |  HIGH  |
| India MAU                     | 491M (~20% of global)             | DataReportal Digital 2025   | #08       |  HIGH  |
| India 2029 Forecast           | 859M (+75%)                       | Statista                    | #08       |  MED   |
| Total Revenue 2025            | \$60B+ (Alphabet confirmed)       | Alphabet Q4 2025 SEC Filing | #04       |  HIGH  |
| Shorts Daily Views (Jan 2026) | 200B (confirmed Neal Mohan)       | blog.youtube                | #02       |  HIGH  |
| Long-Form Share of Watch Time | 70%+ of total YouTube watch time  | Zebracat; Mediacube         | #02       |  HIGH |
| TV vs Mobile (US, H1 2025)    | TV 36% vs Mobile 29% of hours     | Señal News / Variety        | #13       |  MED |
| Long-Form on TV Watch Time    | 73% of TV watch time (↑ from 65%) | Advanced Television         | #13       |  MED |
| Global CTV Devices            | 2.65B (2025) → 4.2B by 2030       | Broadband TV News           | #13       |  MED |

#### So What? - Implication for Discovery

*Long-form is the consumption majority (70%+ of watch time) but is losing feed surface area as Shorts absorbs browse real estate. The CTV device shift reinforces long-form dominance - users watching on a television self-select for lean-back, longer content.*

*For Discovery: the feed optimisation problem is not about surfacing more long-form; it is about surfacing the right long-form at the right moment on the right device. CTV-specific ranking signals are currently underweighted in our recommendation stack.*

**ASSUMPTION FLAG:** CTV and viewing-hour data (Insight #13) is US-only with no disclosed sample size for session length. India CTV penetration data is absent from our dataset - do not extrapolate.

### 4.2 India's YouTube Ads Statistics 2024

India's digital ad market was approximately \$6.98B in FY24 (Exchange4Media), with YouTube claiming an estimated 20–22% of India's digital ad spend and capturing ~38% of India's total OTT revenue share in FY 2024–25 (MediaNews4U ⚠ MED). These figures rely on third-party attribution - see Gap G6.

The short-form ad market globally is growing at 13.68% CAGR vs 9.54% for all digital video - projected to hit \$219.71B by 2030 (Statista ⚠ MED). This CAGR differential means ad budget is flowing toward Shorts faster. However, per-view creator economics tell a different story for supply incentives.

| Metric                            | Long-Form              | Shorts                     | Source                    |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------|----------------------------|---------------------------|
| Creator RPM (per 1K views)        | \$3–\$6                | \$0.03–\$0.07              | Digiday                   |
| Revenue/watch-hour parity (US)    | ~equal (as of Q3 2025) | ~equal (as of Q3 2025)     | Alphabet Q3 2025 Earnings |
| Creator revenue share             | 55% of ad revenue      | 45% of shared pool         | Riverside.fm              |
| US CPM (advertiser-side)          | \$15–\$33              | ~\$4                       | Gupta Media CPM Tracker   |
| Short-form ad spend CAGR (global) | -                      | 13.68% → \$219.71B by 2030 | Statista                  |

#### So What? - Implication for Discovery

India is YouTube's largest market by users but monetises almost entirely via ads. Every recommendation decision in India is an ad impression decision. Premium is not a meaningful buffer.

The per-view/per-hour paradox matters for creator supply: creators observe per-view earnings and rationally deprioritise Shorts. Yet per-watch-hour parity (confirmed Q3 2025) is not yet widely internalised. Discovery needs healthy long-form supply; RPM structure directly influences what creators build.

**DATA GAP - G6:** India-specific ad revenue breakdown and Shorts' actual % of YouTube total ad revenue are NOT available in our dataset. The ~22% Shorts figure circulating in industry reports is analyst inference, not Alphabet disclosure. Do not use in financial projections.

#### 4.3 Demographics-Related Data

| Demographic Dimension           | Data Point                     | Source    | Insight # | Conf. |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|-----------|-----------|-------|
| Gen Z long-form preference      | 51% call it a favourite format | eMarketer | #14       | ⚠ MED |
| Millennial long-form preference | 40% call it a favourite format | eMarketer | #14       | ⚠ MED |
| Gen Z - short-form viewership   | 61.6% watch short-form         | eMarketer | #14       | ⚠ MED |
| Gen Z - long-form viewership    | 53.1% ALSO watch long-form     | eMarketer | #14       | ⚠ MED |



|                                     |                                           |                                  |          |       |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|----------|-------|
| Session abandonment (all ages)      | 19% abandon without watching              | Nielsen Gracenote 2025 (n=3,000) | #09      | ⚠ MED |
| Session abandonment (18–24 yrs)     | <b>29% abandon - 53% higher than avg</b>  | Nielsen Gracenote 2025 (n=3,000) | #09, #14 | ⚠ MED |
| Avg search time per session         | <b>12 min (up 60% from 7.5 min, 2019)</b> | Nielsen Gracenote 2025 (n=3,000) | #09      | ⚠ MED |
| Millennials binge-watching YT daily | 37%                                       | CTAM State of Gen Z 2024         | #14      | ⚠ MED |

### So What? - Implication for Discovery

Gen Z does not reject long-form - they reject the friction of finding it. The preference gap (51% favour long-form) vs consumption gap (29% Gen Z session abandonment) is a Discovery problem, not a content problem.

A 12-minute search overhead on a typical 40-minute YouTube session represents ~30% of session time spent not watching. Reducing this overhead by even 30% unlocks 3–4 additional monetisable minutes per session, per user.

**ASSUMPTION FLAG:** Nielsen Gracenote 2025 (Insight #09) covers all streaming platforms, not YouTube specifically. Preference data (eMarketer) and abandonment data (Nielsen) are from two separate studies - the causal link is inferred, not directly measured.

## 4.4 Behavioral Analysis- Long Form (The Old King) Vs Short form (The new kid in town)

| Dimension                      | Long-Form                                              | Short-Form                                            | Direction | Source                                     |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------|--------------------------------------------|
| Share of total watch time      | <b>70%+</b>                                            | ~10% (up from near-zero in 2021)                      | → LF      | Zebracat; Mediacube<br>⚠ MED               |
| TV viewing time share (US)     | <b>73% (↑ from 65% YoY)</b>                            | N/A disclosed                                         | → LF      | Advanced Television<br>⚠ MED               |
| US device primacy              | TV - 36% of hours (H1 2025)                            | Mobile - 29% of hours                                 | → LF      | Señal News / Variety<br>⚠ MED              |
| 2025 algo update impact        | <b>-90% ultra-long-form; -21% avg top video length</b> | Indirectly boosted Shorts shelf                       | ← SF      | TubeFilter / Little Dot Feb 2026<br>✅ HIGH |
| Within-channel cannibalization | <b>Long-form engagement lower post-Shorts launch</b>   | <b>Shorts attract 110x more views on same channel</b> | ← SF      | arXiv 2402.18208 n=250<br>⚠ MED            |
| YoY engagement trend (2025)    | <b>Instructional 5–30 min held at 58% engagement</b>   | <b>Shorts -47%; Reels -59%</b>                        | → LF      | Wistia 2025; Metricool 2025<br>✅ HIGH      |

|                            |                                             |                                             |      |                                              |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|------|----------------------------------------------|
| Post/upload volume trend   | Stable supply                               | +71% posts but engagement 4-year low        | ← LF | Wistia 2025; Metricool 2025  HIGH            |
| Cross-format growth effect | Channels posting both: 40–60% faster growth | Channels posting both: 40–60% faster growth | Both | <i>dataslayer.ai</i> ; <i>awisee.com</i> LOW |

### So What? - Implication for Discovery

*Long-form is alive on CTV and in total watch time, but is losing mobile feed real estate and within-channel attention to Shorts. Short-form itself is showing fatigue. The opportunity is in the bridge - which is currently unmeasured.*

*The cross-format bridge (Shorts→long-form) is the most commercially important thesis in this PRD - and entirely unverified at the platform level. YouTube has never disclosed Shorts→long-form transition rates (Gap G1, G7).*

**ASSUMPTION FLAG:** Causal cannibalization (arXiv n=250, Insight #07) is a single study with no Tier-1 replication. Cross-format growth figures (Insight #11) come exclusively from creator analytics blogs - no first-party YouTube confirmation. Treat as directional, not actionable design inputs in isolation.

## 4.5 Content Analysis- Ecosystem Growth

| Content Type                    | Edit Time         | Approx. Cost                     | Source                              |
|---------------------------------|-------------------|----------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| One long-form video (10–15 min) | 12–20 hrs         | ~\$500–\$800                     | offshoreclipping.com  MED           |
| Five Shorts                     | 2–4 hrs total     | ~\$100–\$200                     | offshoreclipping.com + CutJamm  MED |
| AI editing adoption rate (2025) | 50%+ of all video | Lowers cost; effort gap persists | Wistia 2025 State of Video  HIGH    |
| AI editing market               | -                 | \$1.6B (2025) → \$9.3B by 2030   | Virtue Market Research  MED         |

The competitor graveyard for cross-format discovery features is comprehensive. Every platform that bolted a cross-format feature onto an existing product killed it within 2 years, with the partial exception of Netflix autoplay - which reduced friction within a single format rather than mixing formats.

| Platform  | Feature | Outcome                                       | Lesson for YouTube Discovery                                                      |
|-----------|---------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Instagram | IGTV    | <7M downloads / 1B+ users. Killed March 2022. | Bolted-on surfaces fail. Users won't leave their feed for a separate destination. |

|         |                              |                                                          |                                                                                                         |
|---------|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Netflix | 'Play Something'             | Killed Jan 2023, <2 yrs.<br>No data released.            | Serendipity without context doesn't build trust. Users need to understand WHY something is recommended. |
| Netflix | 'Fast Laughs'                | Discontinued. No data released.                          | Format mixing requires intent signal, not surface mixing.                                               |
| Netflix | Autoplay                     | Increased long-form consumption (n=76).<br>Still active. | Reducing friction WITHIN format works. The win is in the existing feed, not new surfaces.               |
| TikTok  | Long-form expansion (60 min) | >1 min creators gain 5x more followers.                  | Even short-form platforms pursue long-form. YouTube's window to consolidate advantage is narrowing.     |

### So What? - Implication for Discovery

*The ecosystem is growing on the supply side and is resilient in specific genres (gaming, tutorials) that are natural long-form formats with high watch-time per session.*

*The competitor graveyard is unambiguous: every bolted-on cross-format discovery feature has failed within 2 years. Any Discovery solution must be native to the existing feed, not a new surface. The Netflix autoplay finding is the positive signal - reducing friction within format works.*

**ASSUMPTION FLAG:** Gaming hours (Insight #10) sourced from an AI-generated blog (alexandremacmillan.com via Gemini Deep Research) - not corroborated by StreamCharts or Tier-1 source. Use directionally only. Creator effort cost derived from two separate datasets, not a head-to-head study - see Insight #06.

## 4.6 Why do people choose Youtube over other platforms?

This section synthesises platform differentiation strictly from our secondary dataset. YouTube's structural advantages are real and durable - but each has a corresponding Discovery friction point that undermines it. The core tension: YouTube wins on every structural dimension yet the average user still spends 12 minutes per session finding something to watch, and 29% of Gen Z sessions end without a single video played.

| YouTube Advantage                                    | Supporting Data                                                                                                                | The Friction Point                                                                                               |
|------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Depth &amp; volume of long-form content</b>       | 70%+ watch time long-form; genre resilience (gaming, tutorials). 20M new uploads/day; ~20B total videos.                       | 2025 algo update cut ultra-long-form viewership by 90%. Content exists - recommendation layer is suppressing it. |
| <b>Multi-device ecosystem / CTV leadership</b>       | TV overtook mobile (36% vs 29% US hours, H1 2025). CTV 2.65B → 4.2B by 2030. No social competitor has meaningful CTV presence. | CTV-specific ranking signals not known to be separately weighted in current recommendation models.               |
| <b>Creator economics - highest RPM for long-form</b> | \$60B+ total revenue. Long-form CPM \$15-\$33 (US). 55% creator revenue share on long-form vs 45% for Shorts pool.             | 59% of creators say consistent production is #1 challenge. AI accelerates Shorts supply asymmetrically.          |

|                                                      |                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                |
|------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Format breadth (long + short on one platform)</b> | Channels posting both formats grow 40–60% faster. Shorts 200B daily views. Long-form 70%+ watch time.   | Shorts→long-form funnel efficiency has never been measured by YouTube (Gap G1, G7).                            |
| <b>Scale of personalisation infrastructure</b>       | Algorithm drives 70% of all watch time (1B+ hours daily). 2-stage DNN + LLMs for content understanding. | Average search time is 12 min/session (+60% vs 2019). Discovery friction is growing despite world-class infra. |

### So What? - Implication for Discovery

*YouTube wins on content library depth, creator economics, and CTV scale - advantages no competitor can replicate at this scale in the near term. The existential risk is not TikTok taking viewers; it is YouTube losing watch time to decision fatigue - a self-inflicted wound.*

*Every structural advantage in the table has a corresponding Discovery friction point that erodes it. This is the design brief: reduce friction inside the existing feed, improve long-form surfacing on CTV where it already thrives, and validate the Shorts→long-form funnel rather than assuming it works.*

## 4.6 Conclusion

### What the Data Tells Us

Long-form content is not in structural decline - it represents 70%+ of total YouTube watch time and is growing its share of CTV viewing (65%→73% YoY). The problem is displacement within the feed and algorithm, not a collapse in consumption.

Short-form itself is showing measurable fatigue. Despite post volume surging 71% YoY, Shorts interactions fell 47% and Reels views fell 59% in 2025. Supply has outpaced engagement, compressing attention per post.

The discovery problem is quantifiably real. Users now spend 12 minutes per session searching - up 60% since 2019 - and 29% of Gen Z sessions end without a single view. This is not a content quality problem. It is a feed design problem.

The "Gen Z rejects long-form" thesis is empirically false. 51% of Gen Z name long-form as a favourite social format, compared to 40% of Millennials, and 53.1% actively watch it. The barrier is discovery friction, not format preference.

### Critical Gap to Acknowledge

| Hypothesis                                            | Status                                         | Missing Data                                             |
|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Shorts act as top-of-funnel for long-form consumption | Directionally supported by creator growth data | Shorts → long-form session transition rate not disclosed |

 **Open Question:** The Shorts→long-form session transition rate is the single most important metric for validating this PRD's core hypothesis. It is entirely unverified at the platform level and must be treated as the **#1 assumption to test** before committing to solution design.

### Implication for This PRD

The opportunity is not to make long-form content or build more of it. The opportunity is to fix the feed layer that is failing to connect willing audiences to content they would watch. Discovery is broken. The audience exists. The content exists. The gap is the bridge between them.

| Gap | Question Not Answered by Secondary Research                                                                                      | Hypotheses Linked |
|-----|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| G1  | What % of long-form views originate from Shorts? YouTube has never disclosed this — the entire funnel thesis is unverified.      | H2, H8            |
| G2  | What drives creator format decisions — RPM, algorithmic reach, or effort? RPM gap is documented; behavioural implication is not. | H6, H11           |
| G3  | Did India's ~33% short-form MAU drop (Josh/Moj) mean long-form re-engagement or migration to YouTube Shorts?                     | H14, H6           |
| G4  | What is the actual homepage real-estate split? The 12→3 long-form slot claim is from a single unverified blog.                   | H7, H8            |
| G5  | Does Wistia's 'engagement 4-year low' apply to consumer YouTube? Wistia is a B2B video platform.                                 | H1, H12           |
| G6  | What is Shorts' actual % of YouTube ad revenue? The ~22% figure is analyst inference, not Alphabet disclosure.                   | H6, H12           |
| G7  | What user-level data exists on the Shorts→long-form transition path? Session-level transition rate never published.              | H2, H8            |

[This dashboard synthesises 27+ external sources across market data](#), behavioral research, demographic studies, and competitive analysis — structured as a 7-chapter brief to support the problem framing in this PRD. Every data point is tagged with a confidence tier, and the 7 open data gaps are called out explicitly so we're honest about what we know vs. what we're assuming. Read this before you review the solution section.